

Open Worship Open Ministry Meeting

prc-open-worship-open-ministry-meeting

Worship Structure · Service Form · practice · minority_lineages · brethren distinctive

DISPUTED

Supported across many Bible texts

Subject named directly in Scripture

Holds across manuscript variants

Statement under examination

A meeting in which qualified brothers may, as the Spirit leads, contribute audibly (reading, praying, giving thanks, suggesting a hymn, sharing a word) reflects the participatory pattern Paul describes in 1 Corinthians 14:26-33.

In plain language

First Corinthians 14:26-33 describes a Christian gathering in which more than one person contributes out loud. Verse 26 opens, 'when you come together' (ὅταν συνέρχησθε, hotan synerchēsthe), then says 'each one' (ἕκαστος, hekastos) 'has' (ἔχει, echei), and lists a psalm, a teaching, a revelation, a tongue, and an interpretation, picturing different members each bringing something. Verse 31 adds 'you can all prophesy one by one' (δύνασθε καθ' ἓνα πάντες προφητεῦειν, dynasthe kath' hena pantes prophēteuein), so that all may learn and all be encouraged. A key grammatical detail explains where readers divide. The words for the contributions, 'has' in verse 26 and 'you can' in verse 31, are stated as plain facts, in the indicative mood (ongoing, simple statement of fact), so Paul is describing what happens when the church assembles. The words that give commands, in the imperative mood (direct command), attach not to the open format but to its aim and its order: 'let all be done for building up' in verse 26, let an interpreter be present, let only two or three speak, let them take turns, let the others weigh what is said, and at the end 'let all be done decently and in order' in verse 40. So the text commands edification (building up) and order, and describes, rather than commands, the every-member format. That is why the basic shape the proposition points to is genuinely present, while whether it is a binding pattern for all worship is left open by the words themselves. The reciprocal language of Colossians 3:16 and Ephesians 5:19, teaching and admonishing 'one another' (ἑαυτούς, heautous) and speaking to 'one another' in song, supports mutual participation, but those phrases describe the manner of being filled with the Spirit and letting the word dwell, not a regulated meeting order. The proposition also adds that contributors are limited to qualified brothers, which leans on the separate and contested silence clause a few verses later, and the canon elsewhere also speaks of a recognized teaching role for elders, which the vocabulary here does not rank against the every-member pattern. Because the words clearly support audible, multi-member participation but do not on their own settle the normativity claim or the brothers-only restriction packed into the statement, the lexical verdict is disputed rather than a plain yes or no.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
G0181	ἀκαταστασία	akatastasia	disorder	5
G0240	ἀλλήλων	allēlōn	one another	101
G0243	ἄλλος	allos	another	
G0303	ἑκά	ana	each	

G0602	ἀποκάλυψις	apokalupsis	revelation	
G1100	γλῶσσα	glōssa	tongue	
G1322	διδαχή	didachē	teaching	
G1417	δύο	duo	two	
G1438	ἑαυτοῦ	heautou	themselves	331
G1520	εἷς	heis	one	367
G1538	ἕκαστος	hekastos	each	91
G1577	ἐκκλησία	ekklēsia	assembly	119
G2192	ἔχω	echō	to have/be	765
G2316	θεός	theos	God	
G3619	οἰκοδομή	oikodomē	building	18
G3956	πᾶς	pas	all	1,316
G4395	προφητεύω	prophēteuō	to prophesy	28
G4396	προφήτης	prophētēs	prophet	149
G4601	σιγάω	sigāō	be silent	10
G4905	συνέρχομαι	sunerchomai	to assemble	
G5010	τάξις	taxis	order	10
G5140	τρεῖς	treis	Three	
G5293	ὑποτάσσω	hypotassō	to subject	42
G5568	ψαλμός	psalmos	psalm	7

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: False

The participatory shape is plainly attested at the level of description. In 1 Corinthians 14:26 the distributive subject 'each one' (ἕκαστος, hekastos, 91 New Testament occurrences, stable sense) governs the verb 'has' (ἔχει, echei) repeated five times, and that verb is present active INDICATIVE (ongoing, simple statement of fact), so Paul states what happens when the gathered church assembles ('when you come together', ὅταν συνέρχησθε, hotan synerchēsthe), not a command to do it. Likewise 14:31, 'you are able...to prophesy' (δύνασθε...προφητεύειν, dynasthe...prophēteuein), is indicative plus infinitive (you are able to prophesy), with 'one by one' (καθ' ἓνα, kath' hena) marking one by one turns. The only IMPERATIVES (direct commands) in the unit attach to purpose and order, not to the open format: 'let it be done for building up' (γινέσθω πρὸς οἰκοδομὴν, ginesthō pros oikodomēn) in 14:26, 'let him interpret' (διερμηνεύτω, diermēneuētō), 'let him keep silent' (σιγάτω, sigatō), 'let them speak' (λαλείτωσαν, laleitōsan), 'let them weigh' (διακρινέτωσαν, diakrinetōsan) in 14:27-30, and 'let it be done in order' (κατὰ τάξιν γινέσθω, kata taxin ginesthō) in 14:40. The verdict is disputed because the grammar describes the every-member contribution but commands only edification (building up) and order, so the text does not by itself fix whether this is a mandated worship form or the regulation of one charismatic (Spirit-gifted) assembly. The stem also imports a brothers-only limit drawn from the separate 14:34 clause, which 26-33 does not lexically supply.

Scripture

1Cor.14.23 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4905 συνέρχομαι, G1577 ἐκκλησία

Reasoning. 'If the whole church comes together to the same place' (συνέλθῃ ἡ ἐκκλησία ὅλη ἐπὶ τὸ αὐτό, synelthē hē ekklēsia holē epi to auto) fixes the setting for the unit: 'come together' (συνέρχομαι, synerchomai) is the assembly-gathering verb, the same verb that opens 1 Corinthians 14:26 as 'when you come together' (ὅταν συνέρχησθε, hotan synerchēsthe). This locates the every-member contribution of 14:26 specifically in the gathered church meeting and not in general daily life, which strengthens the participatory reading at the descriptive level.

1Cor.14.26 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1538 ἕκαστος, G2192 ἔχω, G3619 οἰκοδομή

Reasoning. The distributive subject 'each one' (ἕκαστος, hekastos) governs 'has' (ἔχει, echei) five times, and the morphology marks 'has' (ἔχει, echei) as present active INDICATIVE (ongoing, simple statement of fact) third person singular, so the verse states what occurs when they assemble ('a psalm', ψαλμόν, psalmon; 'a teaching', διδαχήν, didachēn; 'a revelation', ἀποκάλυψιν, apokalypsin; 'a tongue', γλῶσσαν, glōssan; 'an interpretation', ἑρμηνείαν, hermēneian) rather than commanding it. The single imperative (direct command) is 'let it be done' (γινέσθω, ginesthō), and it governs not the open format but the purpose 'all things for building up' (πάντα πρὸς οἰκοδομήν, panta pros oikodomēn). So the grammar describes the contributions and commands only their edifying (building up) aim. This is the central verse for the participatory shape and also the central reason the format itself is not lexically mandated here.

1Cor.14.27 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1417 δύο, G5140 τρεῖς

Reasoning. The numerical caps 'by two or at most three' (κατὰ δύο ἢ τὸ πλεῖστον τρεῖς, kata dyo ē to pleiston treis) and 'in turn, one at a time' (ἀνὰ μέρος, ana meros), together with the imperative (direct command) 'let him interpret' (διερμηνεύτω, diermēneueto) requiring an interpreter, show the openness is bounded and conditioned. The imperative mood here regulates who may voice a contribution and how, which complicates a reading of the meeting as unrestricted free participation.

1Cor.14.29 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4396 προφήτης, G0243 ἄλλος

Reasoning. 'Let two or three prophets speak' (προφῆται δὲ δύο ἢ τρεῖς λαλείτωσαν, prophētai de dyo ē treis laleitōsan) again caps the speakers by an imperative (direct command), while 'let the others weigh' (οἱ ἄλλοι διακρινέτωσαν, hoi alloi diakrinetōsan) is a third person plural imperative assigning the rest of the gathered an active discerning role. The plural imperatives distribute speaking and discernment across the assembly, supporting a participatory shape that is nonetheless under command and order.

1Cor.14.31 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3956 πᾶς, G4395 προφητεύω

Reasoning. 'For you can all prophesy one by one' (δύνασθε γὰρ καθ' ἓνα πάντες προφητεύειν, dynasthe gar kath' hena pantes prophēteuein) is the broadest warrant for participation, but 'you are able' (δύνασθε, dynasthe) is present indicative (ongoing, simple statement of fact: you are able) plus the infinitive 'to prophesy' (προφητεύειν, prophēteuein), a statement of capacity rather than a command to adopt a format. The distributive 'one by one' (καθ' ἓνα, kath' hena) marks sequential turns and the purpose 'that all may learn and all be encouraged' (ἵνα πάντες μανθάνωσιν καὶ πάντες παρακαλῶνται, hina pantes manthanōsin kai pantes parakalōntai) ties the capacity to mutual edification (building up). 'All' (πάντες, pantes) occurs three times, generalizing the ability to the gathered believers.

1Cor.14.32 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key terms. G5293 ὑποτάσσω, G4396 προφήτης

Reasoning. 'The spirits of prophets are subject to prophets' (πνεύματα προφητῶν προφήταις ὑποτάσσεται, pneumata prophētōn prophētais hypotassetai), with 'are subject' (ὑποτάσσεται, hypotassetai) a present passive indicative (ongoing, simple statement of fact in the passive voice), places the contributions under the speaker's controllable self-governance. This undercuts a model of irresistible Spirit prompting that overrides order, and it conditions how the spontaneity in the stem ('as the Spirit leads') must operate.

1Cor.14.33 · neutral · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0181 ἀκαταστασία, G2316 θεός

Reasoning. 'For God is not of disorder but of peace' (οὐ γάρ ἐστιν ἀκαταστασίας ὁ θεὸς ἀλλὰ εἰρήνης, ou gar estin akatastasias ho theos alla eirēnēs) supplies the theological rationale governing the whole unit. The contrast 'disorder' (ἀκαταστασία, akatastasia, 5 New Testament occurrences) versus 'peace' (εἰρήνη, eirēnē) frames participation as something to be ordered for peace, which both supports a structured open meeting and warns against unregulated contribution.

1Cor.14.40 · neutral · genre: epistle

Key terms. G5010 τάξις, G3956 πᾶς

Reasoning. 'Let all be done decently and in order' (πάντα δὲ εὐσχημόνως καὶ κατὰ τάξιν γινέσθω, panta de euschēmonōs kai kata taxin ginesthō) closes the chapter with the same imperative (direct command) 'let it be done' (γινέσθω, ginesthō) that governs the purpose in 1 Corinthians 14:26, now governing 'order' (τάξις, taxis). This is the prescriptive counterweight to the descriptive openness: the words that command are about order and seemliness, not about an open format, so the lexical data favor regulated participation rather than either pure spontaneity or a fixed liturgy (a fixed worship script).

Col.3.16 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1438 ἑαυτοῦ, G5568 ψαλμός

Reasoning. The present participles (ongoing '-ing' verb forms) 'teaching and admonishing one another' (διδάσκοντες καὶ νοουθετοῦντες ἑαυτούς, didaskontes kai nouthetountes heautous) in 'psalms, hymns, spiritual songs' (ψαλμοῖς, ὕμνοις, ᾠδαῖς πνευματικαῖς, psalmois, hymnois, ōdais pneumatikais) show mutual member-to-member activity in song and word, but they hang on the imperative (direct command) 'let it dwell' (ἐνοικεῖτω, enoikeitō, 'let the word of Christ dwell'), describing the manner of that indwelling rather than a regulated assembly order. The reflexive 'one another' (ἑαυτούς, heautous) functions reciprocally and broadens the participatory pattern beyond a single instructor.

Eph.5.19 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1438 ἑαυτοῦ, G0240 ἀλλήλων

Reasoning. 'Speaking to one another in psalms and hymns and spiritual songs' (λαλοῦντες ἑαυτοῖς ψαλμοῖς καὶ ὕμνοις καὶ ᾠδαῖς πνευματικαῖς, lalountes heautois psalmois kai hymnois kai ōdais pneumatikais) uses a reciprocal dative (a noun in the 'to-X' grammatical form, here marking mutual address) for mutual address, paralleling Colossians 3:16, and the related 'submitting to one another' (ὑποτασσόμενοι ἀλλήλοις, hypotassomenoi allēlois) in Ephesians 5:21 uses 'one another' (ἀλλήλων, allēlōn). These are present participles (ongoing '-ing' verb forms) dependent on the imperative (direct command) 'be filled' (πληροῦσθε, plērousthe, Ephesians 5:18), so they describe the manner of Spirit-filling and general thanksgiving rather than a regulated worship order, which both supports mutual participation and limits how far it prescribes a meeting form.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
1Cor.14.26	Eph.5.19	openbible	25

1Cor.14.26	Rom.14.19	openbible	15
1Cor.14.26	1Cor.14.40	openbible	6
1Cor.14.40	Titus.1.5	openbible	16
1Cor.14.40	1Cor.14.26	openbible	13
1Cor.14.31	1Thess.5.11	openbible	3
1Cor.14.32	1Cor.14.29	tsk	1
Col.3.16	Col.4.6	tsk	1

Complicating texts

1Cor.14.34 · addressed

The following clause 'let the women keep silent in the churches' (αἱ γυναῖκες ἐν ταῖς ἐκκλησίαις σιγάτωσαν, *hai gynaiques en tais ekklesiāis sigatōsan*) restricts who may speak audibly in the same assembly, which is why the proposition limits contributors to brothers. The verb 'let them keep silent' (σιγάτωσαν, *sigatōsan*) is imperative (a direct command), but this clause sits outside the cited 1 Corinthians 14:26-33 bundle and its scope is itself contested in the wider chapter. It can be read to support the brothers-only specification, but it does not lexically establish the proposition's larger claim that open Spirit-led participation is a normative worship pattern. It complicates rather than confirms and is one ground of the disputed verdict.

1Cor.14.40 · addressed

'Let all be done decently and in order' (πάντα δὲ εὐσχημόνως καὶ κατὰ τάξιν γινέσθω, *panta de euschēmonōs kai kata taxin ginesthō*) closes the chapter by subordinating the openness to decorum and order through the imperative (direct command) 'let it be done' (γινέσθω, *ginesthō*) over 'order' (τάξις, *taxis*). This is addressed in the scripture list as a 'for' and 'neutral' counterweight: the proposition's phrase 'as the Spirit leads' must be read alongside commanded order, so the lexical data favor regulated participation, which the proposition captures only in part.

1Tim.5.17 · unaddressed

The recognized teaching office, 'elders who rule well, who labor in word and teaching' (οἱ καλῶς προεστῶτες πρεσβύτεροι... οἱ κοπιῶντες ἐν λόγῳ καὶ διδασκαλίᾳ, *hoi kalōs proestōtes presbyteroi... hoi kopiōntes en logō kai didaskalia*), and the order language of Titus 1:5 (cross-referenced from 1 Corinthians 14:40) attest a designated, laboring teaching role that coexists with the every-member contribution of 1 Corinthians 14. This is left unresolved because the vocabulary does not rank the two: the canon supplies both an every-member participation pattern and a recognized eldership teaching pattern, and the words do not themselves specify how a meeting should weight or combine them, which is a core reason the normativity question is underdetermined.

Concordance traversed

G1538, G2192, G3956, G4396, G4395, G3619, G5010, G5293, G4601, G0181, G1577, G0240, G1438, G5568, G1520, G1417, G5140, G0303, G4905, G1322, G0602, G1100

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: ecm-shadow

1 Corinthians is outside the open-cbgm 3 John published sample, so CBGM (Coherence-Based Genealogical Method, a textual-criticism technique) data were not consulted directly and no variant units were available in the bundle. The apparatus (textual-variant footnote) markers visible in 1 Corinthians 14:26-30 (transposition of 'a revelation' (ἀποκάλυψιν, *apokalypsin*) and 'a tongue' (γλῶσσαν, *glōssan*), the 'interpreter' (διερμηνευτής, *diērmēneutēs*) reading in 14:28) touch word order and a single lexical choice but not the indicative (ongoing, simple statement of fact) force of 'each one has' (ἐκαστος ἔχει, *hekastos echei*) or 'you are able...to prophesy' (δύνασθε...προφητεῦειν, *dynasthe...prophēteuein*), nor the imperatives (direct commands) 'let it be done' (γινέσθω, *ginesthō*), 'let him keep silent' (σιγάτω, *sigatō*), 'let them speak' (λαλεῖτωσαν, *laleitōsan*). The descriptive versus prescriptive grammar that drives the verdict holds across the readings in view, so the verdict is variant-robust.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. descriptive_vs_prescriptive, continuationism, cessationism

analogia scripturae invoked

descriptive_reading: disputed · Because 'has' (ἔχει, echei) in 1 Corinthians 14:26 and 'you are able' (δύνασθε, dynasthe) in 14:31 are indicative (ongoing, simple statements of fact) and the only imperatives (direct commands) govern edification (building up) and order, this lens reads 14:26-33 as Paul describing and then regulating a specific Corinthian assembly. The participation is real but the open meeting form is not commanded as a universal pattern, so the proposition's normativity claim is underdetermined and the verdict is disputed.

prescriptive_reading: affirms · This lens takes the present indicatives (ongoing, simple statements of fact) 'has' (ἔχει, echei) and 'you are able' (δύνασθε, dynasthe) as describing a settled apostolic norm for the gathered church (located by 'come together' (συνέρχομαι, synerchomai) in 1 Corinthians 14:23, 14:26), reinforced by the reciprocal 'one another' (ἑαυτούς, heautous) and 'one another' (ἀλλήλων, allēlōn) of Colossians 3:16 and Ephesians 5:19. On this reading the every-member, 'one by one' (καθ' ἓνα, kath' hena) contribution is the pattern Paul expects whenever the church assembles, so a meeting open to qualified contributors reflects it directly.

continuationism: affirms · If the prophetic and revelatory gifts described in 1 Corinthians 14:26-31 continue, the participatory open meeting reads as a directly reproducible pattern, since 'each one has' (ἐκαστος ἔχει, hekastos echei) and 'all one by one' (καθ' ἓνα πάντες, kath' hena pantes) describe an ongoing assembly practice that the church should still expect.

cessationism: disputed · If the revelatory gifts ('revelation', ἀποκάλυψις, apokalypsis; 'tongue', γλῶσσα, glōssa; 'prophecy', προφητεία, prophēteia) have ceased, then the chapter regulates a now-historical situation, and only the general principle of ordered mutual edification ('for building up', πρὸς οἰκοδομήν, pros oikodomēn; 'in order', κατὰ τάξιν, kata taxin) transfers. The specific open-ministry form is then underdetermined by the text and left to wisdom rather than command.

The verdict turns on a mood contrast in the Greek: the every-member contribution is stated in the indicative (ongoing, simple statement of fact: 'has', ἔχει, echei; 'you are able', δύνασθε, dynasthe) while the imperatives (direct commands) command edification (building up) and order ('let it be done', γινέσθω, ginesthō; 'let him interpret', διερμηνεύτω, diermēneuētō; 'let him keep silent', σιγάτω, sigatō; 'let them speak', λαλείτωσαν, laleitōsan; 'let them weigh', διακρινέτωσαν, diakrinetōsan; 'let it be done in order', κατὰ τάξιν γινέσθω, kata taxin ginesthō). Analogia scripturae (the principle of reading Scripture in light of Scripture) is engaged by reading 1 Corinthians 14:26-33 with the gathering verb in 14:23, the silence and order clauses of 14:27-28, 14:34, 14:40, and the recognized teaching office of 1 Timothy 5:17 and Titus 1:5.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. Does the lexical data of 1 Corinthians 14:26-33 describe a gathering in which multiple members contribute audibly (reading, prayer, thanksgiving, song, a word), and on what grammatical terms (described practice or commanded form), and who is in view.

The phrase 'the participatory pattern Paul describes' presupposes both that 1 Corinthians 14:26-33 sets a pattern and that an open-ministry meeting matches it, which front-loads part of the verdict. The qualifier 'qualified brothers' imports a gender restriction drawn from 14:34 rather than from 14:26-33. The verdict was derived on the original stem, but the neutralized form isolates the bare lexical questions of who contributes, under what grammatical force, and under what constraint. No VERDICT-CHANGED: the prior disputed verdict is confirmed by the indicative (ongoing, simple statement of fact) versus imperative (direct command) mood evidence gathered in this pass.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	1Cor.14.26

morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	1Cor.14.31
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	1Cor.14.40
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	1Cor.14.23
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G1538
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G5293
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Flags

ecm-shadow · lexically-disputed · cross-tradition-divergent · complicating-unresolved